

SMM Iron Ore Daily

2026-09-17 Thursday · Imported & Domestic Ore · Prices · Supply-Demand · Inventory · Commentary

Source **SMM Data-pro**

Futures Contracts

Closing price

SGX Iron Ore Most-traded Contract **Daily**

95.44 USD/dmt

▼ -0.15 -0.16%

MTD avg **98.38**

As of Sep 16 · vs Sep 15

DCE Iron Ore Most-traded I2701 **Daily**

710.5 yuan/mt

▲ +1.5 +0.21%

MTD avg **722.7**

SMM Iron Ore Price Index

All five MMi as of Sep 17 · vs Sep 16

MMi 61% Port Spot **Daily**

685 yuan/wmt

— 0 0.00%

MTD avg **698**

MMi 58% Port Spot **Daily**

646 yuan/wmt

▲ +1 +0.16%

MTD avg **650**

MMi 65% Port Spot **Daily**

838 yuan/wmt

▲ +3 +0.36%

MTD avg **839**

MMi 61% Seaborne Index **Daily**

96.70 USD/dmt

▲ +0.45 +0.47%

MTD avg **97.17**

MMi 65% Seaborne Index **Daily**

113.95 USD/dmt

▲ +0.45 +0.40%

MTD avg **115.56**

SMM Domestic Ore Composite Index **Daily**

845.94 yuan/mt

▲ +5.64 +0.67%

MTD avg **839.58**

Index as of Sep 11 · vs Sep 10

Key View

Import losses narrowed sharply to -3.97 yuan/mt and the board rose a second day; pre-holiday restocking has started, but hot metal is still falling

The biggest change this period is on the cost side. **The average imported ore margin rose from -13.18 to -3.97 yuan/mt**, a 9.21-yuan improvement, and none of the three reasons SMM gives sits in demand — **lower Australian freight, a stronger yuan against the dollar and a narrower seaborne premium**. C5 Australia→China freight has fallen for three straight sessions, from 18.34 to USD 16.37/mt; lower landed costs improve import economics directly and explain why USD quotes rose broadly today (Indian fines +2.59%, BRBF +1.08%) while most yuan spot prices held flat. On the demand side the **first positive signal** of this decline has appeared: SMM states that some mills have begun restocking ahead of the holiday and that overall iron ore demand still supports prices. Together with the DCE contract rising for a second session to 710.5 yuan/mt, this rebound rests on firmer ground than the past two days. It should not be overstated, though. The same material notes mill losses deepening, end-use demand still weak and blast furnace maintenance increasing; as of Sep 16 hot metal at 2.3991 million mt and the operating rate at 88.93% remain in a downtrend, and there is no new print to overturn that. Inventories offer a structural warning: while the 10-port total drew down 1.1059 million mt for a third straight week, the entire draw sits in fines (-1.5908 million mt) and concentrates (-641,200 mt), whereas **lump built 1.0688 million mt in a single week, up 11.26%**, with pellets also higher. Lump building while lump prices hold flat looks like a structural increase in arrivals, but if it persists it will first compress the lump premium. Structurally high grade remains the strongest end: the indices rose for a second session, the 65% port spot index added 3 yuan to 838 and the **high-low spread widened another 2 yuan to 192 yuan/wmt**, a fourth straight session of widening and 9 yuan up from 183 on Sep 14. On balance prices look **caught between the two, trading in a range** — SMM's view too. How far the rebound runs depends on whether pre-holiday restocking is large enough to offset falling hot metal, while the biggest downside variable remains whether last week's shipment surge (+8.59%) turns port stocks into a build once it lands.

Today's Highlights

◆ **Import losses narrowed sharply; the board rose for a second day.** SMM puts the average imported ore margin at **-3.97 yuan/mt**, up from -13.18, a 9.21-yuan improvement in one period driven by **lower Australian freight, a stronger yuan against the dollar and a narrower seaborne premium**. The DCE most-traded I2701 settled at **710.5 yuan/mt** (+1.5 yuan, +0.21%), higher for a second straight session.

◆ **Pre-holiday restocking has finally started.** SMM states explicitly that **some mills have begun restocking ahead of the holiday and that overall iron ore demand still supports prices** — the first positive demand signal of this decline. It also warns, however, that mill losses are deepening, end-use demand remains weak and blast furnace maintenance is increasing, leaving prices caught in a range with no clear direction.

◆ **Most spot grades closed flat, with BRBF the lone gainer.** At Qingdao Port **BRBF rose 5 yuan to 733 yuan/wmt** while PB fines 673, Mac fines 676, Newman lump 873, SSF 535, Carajas fines 840 and PB lump 868 yuan/wmt all held steady, and Newman fines slipped 2 yuan. USD prices, by contrast, rose across the board: Indian fines +2.59%, BRBF +1.08% and Carajas fines +0.57% to USD 115.58/dmt. The indices rose for a second session, with the **65% port spot index up 3 yuan to 838** and the high-low spread 2 yuan wider at 192 yuan/wmt.

◆ **Port stocks kept drawing down, but the structure has split.** Inventory at the 10 ports fell to **101.9125 million mt** (-1.1059 million mt WoW, -1.07%); fines dropped 1.5908 million mt and concentrates 641,200 mt, while **lump built 1.0688 million mt against the trend (+11.26%)** and pellets added 57,300 mt. Freight kept diverging, with C5 Australia→China down another 4.38% to USD 16.37/mt and C3 Brazil→China up 0.43% to 41.97.

Qingdao Port Imported Ore Spot Prices

yuan/wet mt · tax incl. · 2026-09-16 → 2026-09-17

Product	09-17 (yuan/wmt)	Daily change / %	MTD avg	Last 12 months
PB Fines 60.8% Daily	673	— 0 0.00%	689	
Newman Fines 61.2% Daily	678	▼ -2 -0.29%	696	
Mac Fines 60.8% Daily	676	— 0 0.00%	693	
BRBF 62.5% Daily	733	▲ +5 +0.69%	746	
Newman Lump 63% Daily	873	— 0 0.00%	889	
Super Special Fines (SSF) 56.5% Daily	535	— 0 0.00%	551	
Carajas Fines (IOCJ) 65% Daily	840	— 0 0.00%	844	
PB Lump 61.5% Daily	868	— 0 0.00%	885	

Imported Ore USD Prices & MMi Indices

CFR Qingdao · USD/dry mt

USD prices 2026-09-16 → 2026-09-17

Product	09-17 (USD/dmt)	Daily change / %	MTD avg	Last 12 months
Carajas Fines (IOCJ) 65% Daily	115.58	▲ +0.65 +0.57%	115.81	
PB Lump 61.6% Daily	119.56	▲ +0.08 +0.07%	121.76	
BRBF 62.5% Daily	100.35	▲ +1.07 +1.08%	101.85	
Newman Fines 61.2% Daily	92.52	▲ +0.07 +0.08%	94.78	
Mac Fines 61% Daily	92.23	▲ +0.35 +0.38%	94.32	
Jimblebar Fines 60.5% Daily	90.24	▲ +0.92 +1.03%	90.74	
FMG Blend Fines 58.5% Daily	87.11	▲ +0.63 +0.73%	88.27	
Newman Lump 63% Daily	120.27	▲ +0.37 +0.31%	122.21	
Super Special Fines (SSF) 57% Daily	72.16	▲ +0.33 +0.46%	74.21	
Indian Fines 57% Daily	69.03	▲ +1.74 +2.59%	69.88	

SMM Iron Ore Price Index weekly / monthly statistics

Index	Month-to-date avg	MoM	YTD	Unit	Last 12 months
SMM MMi 61% Iron Ore Seaborne Index Daily	97.17	+1.93%	-8.7%	USD/dmt	
SMM MMi 65% Iron Ore Seaborne Index Daily	115.56	-0.20%	-6.1%	USD/dmt	
SMM MMi 61% Iron Ore Port Spot Index Daily	698	+1.12%	-15.7%	yuan/wmt	
SMM MMi 65% Iron Ore Port Spot Index Daily	839	+0.69%	-6.8%	yuan/wmt	
SMM MMi 58% Iron Ore Port Spot Index Daily	650	+1.71%	-10.0%	yuan/wmt	
SMM China Domestic Ore Composite Price Index Daily	839.58	-0.17%	-4.6%	yuan/mt	

The indices rose for a second straight session with high grade still leading: the 65% port spot index added 3 yuan to 838 (+0.36%), the 58% 1 yuan to 646 and the 61% held at 685 on the seaborne side both the 61% and 65% gained USD 0.45, to 96.70 and 113.95/dmt. The high-low spread widened another 2 yuan to 192 yuan/wmt — a fourth consecutive session of widening, up 9 yuan from 183 on Sep 14.

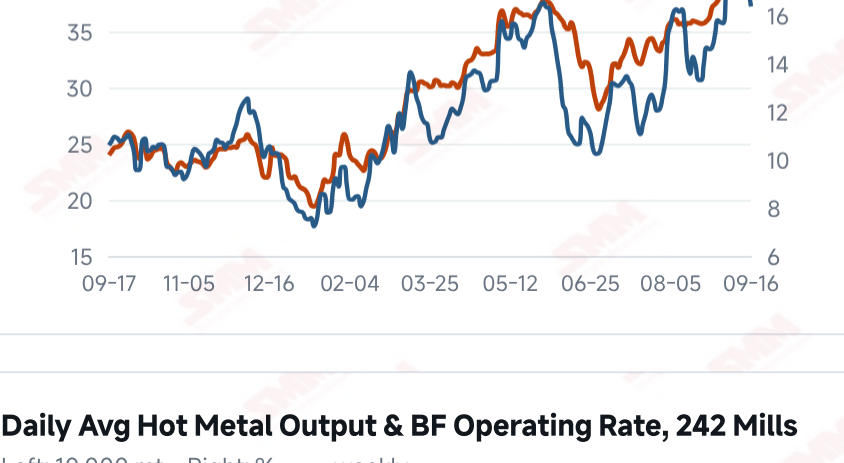
* SMM quotations for Newman Fines and PB Lump (both CNY and USD) start in Mar 2026; their sparklines cover that shorter window only. All others show the past year.

Key Price Drivers

Last 12 months

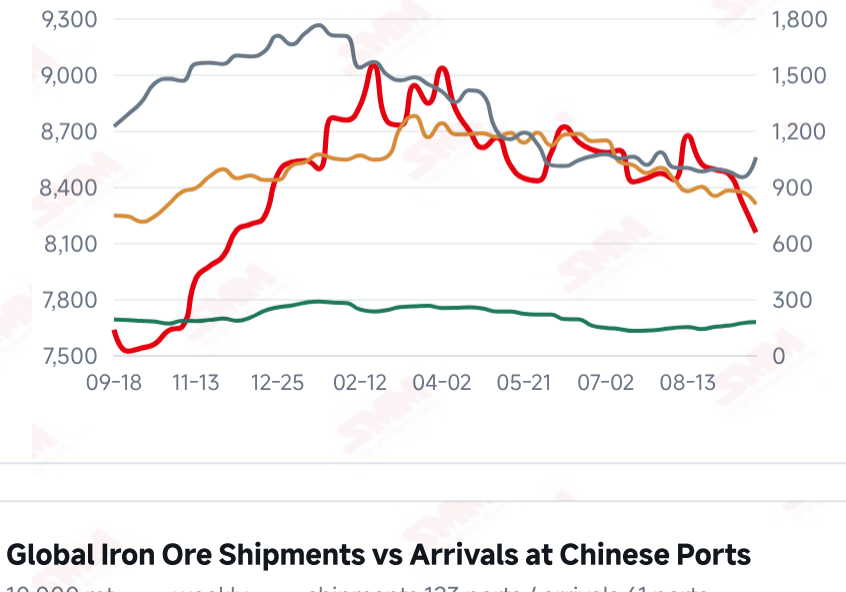
Iron Ore Ocean Freight

USD/mt · last 12M · C3 Tubarao→Beilun/Baoshan, C5 W. Australia Dampier→Qingdao/Beilun/Baoshan



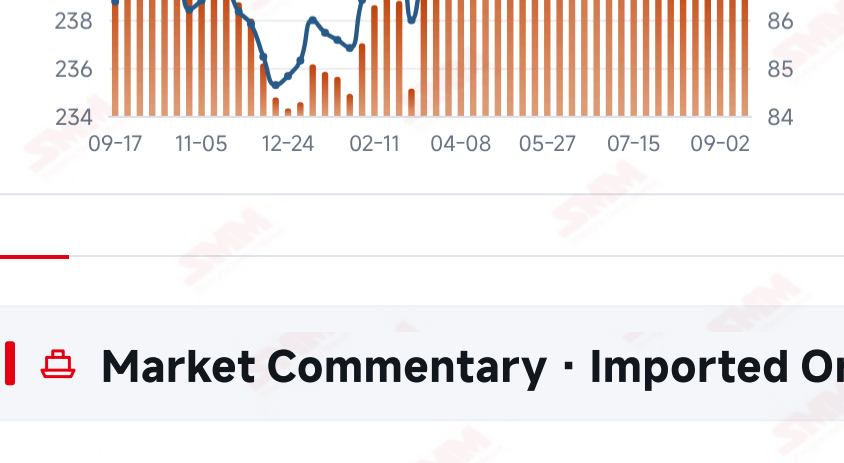
Iron Ore Prices Inventory at 10 Ports · by Product

Left: fines Right: concentrates / lump / pellets · 10,000 mt · weekly



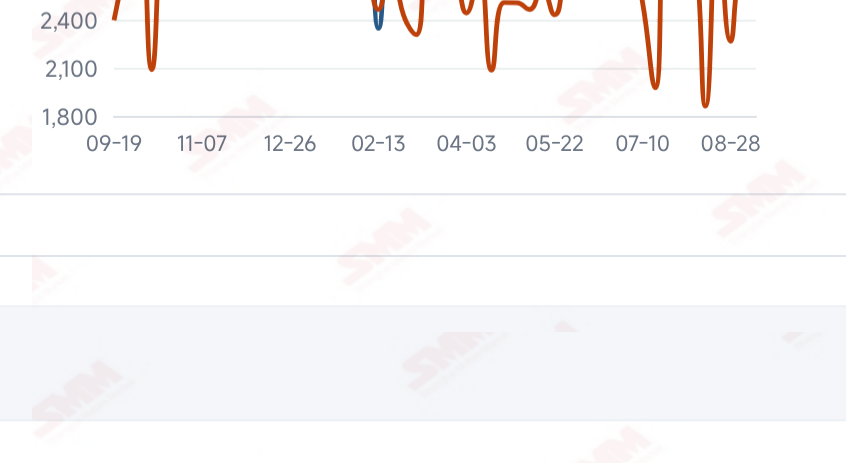
Daily Avg Hot Metal Output & BF Operating Rate, 242 Mills

Left: 10,000 mt Right: % · weekly



Global Iron Ore Shipments vs Arrivals at Chinese Ports

10,000 mt · weekly · shipments 123 ports / arrivals 61 ports



Market Commentary · Imported Ore

Futures & Spot The board extended its recovery. The DCE most-traded I2701 settled at 710.5 yuan/mt, up 1.5 yuan (+0.21%) from Sep 16 and higher for a second straight session; the SGX most-traded contract was at USD 95.44/dmt (as of Sep 16, -0.16%). Most Qingdao Port grades closed flat: PB fines 673, Mac fines 676, Newman lump 873, SSF 535, Carajas fines 840 and PB lump 868 yuan/wmt; **BRBF rose 5 yuan to 733 yuan/wmt**, the only clear gainer, while Newman fines slipped 2 yuan to 678. USD prices moved higher across the board — Indian fines 69.03 (+2.59%), BRBF 100.35 (+1.08%), Carajas fines 115.58 (+0.57%) and SSF 72.16 (+0.46%)/dmt. The ranking differs from the yuan quotes, mainly because the steel strengthened against the dollar on the day.

Driver This period's driver sits on the cost side rather than in demand. SMM lists three reasons for the margin recovery: **lower Australian freight, a stronger yuan against the dollar and a narrower seaborne premium**. C5 Australia→China freight has now fallen for three straight sessions, from 18.34 to USD 16.37/mt; lower landed costs improve import economics directly and reduce the need for traders to hold out on price — which is also why USD quotes rose broadly while most yuan spot prices held flat.

Demand **The first positive signal of this decline has appeared.** SMM states that **some mills have begun restocking ahead of the holiday and that overall iron ore demand still supports prices**. The negatives have not gone away, though: SMM's survey shows mill losses deepening, end-use demand still weak and blast furnace maintenance increasing. As of Sep 16 the blast furnace operating rate across 242 mills was 88.93% (-0.15 ppt) and daily average hot metal 2.3991 million mt (-3,700 mt), still in a downtrend, with no new print this period. SMM therefore sees prices **caught between the two and trading in a range**, with import margins staying in loss until end-use demand genuinely improves.

Inventory & Supply The 10-port series updated to Sep 17: total inventory 101.9125 million mt, down 1.1059 million mt WoW (-1.07%) and a third consecutive weekly draw. **The product mix, however, has clearly split:** fines built 1.0688 million mt (-1.91%) and concentrates 641,200 mt (-7.38%), so the drawdown is concentrated in fines, while **lump built 1.0688 million mt against the trend, a 11.26% weekly rise**, and pellets added 57,300 mt (+3.38%). Lump building while PB lump and Newman lump prices held flat points to a structural increase in arrivals rather than weaker demand. Other weekly data still stand as of Sep 11: 35-port inventory 143.49 million mt (-420,000 mt), daily outbound volume 3.235 million mt (+90,000 mt), imported ore stocks at 242 mills 74.24 million mt (-440,000 mt) with 19.3 days of consumption; global shipments 37.4058 million mt (+8.59%), Australia 20.7583 million mt (+10.18%) and Brazil 7.8627 million mt (-7.62%).

Cost & Margin **The biggest change this period.** The average imported ore margin rose from -13.18 to -3.97 yuan/mt, a 9.21-yuan improvement that SMM attributes to lower Australian freight, a stronger yuan against the dollar and a narrower seaborne premium. The two routes keep diverging: C5 Australia→China fell another USD 0.75 to 16.37/mt (-4.38%), down for a third straight session, while C3 Brazil→China recovered USD 0.18 to 41.97/mt (+0.43%, both as of Sep 16). C3's rebound lines up with BRBF leading the gains and Carajas fines holding firm — Brazilian route costs still support Brazilian grades. SMM expects import margins to stay in loss until end-use demand genuinely improves.

Market Commentary · Domestic Ore

Prices The SMM China Domestic Ore Composite Price Index still reads 845.94 yuan/mt (as of Sep 11, +0.67%), with no new print this week. Regional quotes have turned lower recently: Shandong 64% alkaline concentrate is down to 816 yuan/mt ex-mine and Tangshan 66% concentrate to 935–940 yuan/mt delivered, dry basis and tax inclusive.

Supply & Demand Supply stays tight: concentrator run rates remain low, state-owned operations largely consume their own output and private concentrate supply is short. On demand, deepening mill losses keep buyers pressing hard on domestic concentrate prices, though the start of pre-holiday restocking puts something of a floor under essential requirements.

Outlook Imported high grade has strengthened for two sessions, and if that holds it will support domestic concentrate on relative value. With mill losses deepening and end-use demand weak, however, domestic ore should stay soft and rangebound near term. The next print of the national composite index is worth watching and should reflect the past fortnight's regional pullback.

Market Factors

▲ Supportive factors

- The average imported ore margin rose from -13.18 to -3.97 yuan/mt, a 9.21-yuan improvement in one period.
- SMM says some mills have begun pre-holiday restocking and that demand still supports prices.
- The DCE contract rose 1.5 yuan to 710.5 yuan/mt, higher for a second straight session.
- The 10 ports drew down for a third week, with fines -1.5908 million mt and concentrates -641,200 mt.
- USD prices rose across the board: Indian fines +2.59%, BRBF +1.08%, Carajas fines +0.57%.
- C3 Brazil→China freight recovered 0.43%, still supporting the cost base for Brazilian grades.

▼ Bearish factors

- SMM's survey shows mill losses deepening, end-use demand weak and blast furnace maintenance increasing.
- Hot metal at 2.3991 million mt and the operating rate at 88.93% (Sep 16) remain in a downtrend.
- Lump at the 10 ports built 1.0688 million mt against the trend, up 11.26% in a week, with pellets also higher.
- C5 freight fell for a third straight session, from 18.34 to 16.37/mt, weakening cost support.
- SMM sees prices caught in a range with import margins staying in loss for now.
- Global shipments rose 8.59% last week with Australia above 20 million mt; that cargo has yet to land.

Flash News

Last 2 days · click to open

- SMM Imported Iron Ore Cost & Margin Table, Sep 17, 2026 (margin -13.18→-3.97 yuan/mt; some mills begin pre-holiday restocking)
- Iron Ore Inventory at 10 Ports by Product, Sep 17, 2026 (101.91 million mt, -1.10 million mt WoW; lump and pellets build)
- [SMM Blast Furnace Operating Rate] Maintenance weighs; hot metal output keeps falling (2.3991 million mt, -3,700 mt)
- Ocean Freight and Dry Bulk Shipping Indices, Sep 16
- Key Enterprise Steel Output and Inventory, Early September 2026 (pig iron 1.795 million mt/day, +1.7%)

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